

Establishing Governance and Writing a Clarified Specification

Set the standard everything else gets checked against, then write against it.

What You'll Learn

- 1 Encode project or per-service governance in a constitution
- 2 Write a spec from both a feature request and a defect report using EARS-style requirements
- 3 Run a clarify pass to surface ambiguity before planning
- 4 Map the SDD lifecycle onto your team's existing SDLC

The Constitution

Encodes principles, code quality standards, testing requirements, and architectural constraints.

Written once up front, informed by Module 2's discovery, and checked against by every later phase.

Without it, every generated plan and every piece of code is evaluated against nothing.

EARS-Style Requirements and Clarify

EARS format: "When/if [condition]... the system shall [response]." Testable, unambiguous, one behavior per statement.

Specs come from two different sources on this course: a new-feature request and an existing defect pulled from the tracker.

A clarify pass surfaces ambiguities and edge cases before they get baked into a plan.

The SDD lifecycle isn't a separate process: it maps onto the SDLC you already run.

Constitution and clarified spec approximate requirements and design.

Plan and tasks approximate technical design and iteration planning.

Checklist and analyze approximate QA and test planning. Implement approximates development. Review and living docs approximate code review, QA, and maintenance.

APPLYING THE CONCEPTS

GitHub Spec Kit

Constitution, Specify, Clarify

`/speckit.constitution`

Creates or updates the constitution and keeps dependent templates in sync.

`/speckit.specify`

Creates the feature spec from natural language, focused on what and why, not tech stack.

`/speckit.clarify`

Asks up to five targeted questions about underspecified areas and encodes your answers back into spec.md. Run it as many times as needed.

APPLYING THE CONCEPTS

OpenSpec

Config Files, Deltas, and Explore

Governance gap: No dedicated governance command: project conventions live in openspec/config.yaml rather than a generated document.

`/opsx:propose`

Generates proposal.md plus delta specs/ marking ADDED, MODIFIED, REMOVED requirements, each with Given/When/Then scenarios: OpenSpec's equivalent of testable acceptance criteria.

Clarify gap: No single dedicated clarify command: ambiguity gets sharpened beforehand with /opsx:explore, or reconciled afterward with /opsx:update.

Module 3 at a Glance

	GitHub Spec Kit	OpenSpec
Governance	/speckit.constitution (dedicated command)	openspec/config.yaml (no generated document)
Spec writing	/speckit.specify	/opsx:propose (delta specs, Given/When/Then)
Clarify	/speckit.clarify (dedicated command)	/opsx:explore before, /opsx:update after

Key Takeaways

- Governance has to exist before code is judged against it.
- EARS keeps requirements testable regardless of which framework carries them.
- Clarify early: it's cheap now and expensive once a plan is built on top of ambiguity.